

Chapter 4

Which Vision of Education for Late Modernity?



S. Karin Amos

4.1 Introduction

With the title, “Which Visions of Education for Late Modernity?” I wish to propose that we are actually working with two unknown variables: We are neither certain what will become of education as we know it – both with regards to its institutional as well as its organizational structures – nor do we yet know for certain what it means to live in an era that shows continuities as well as ruptures with what we designate as modernity. In lack of a better term, we refer to this new era, or rather this era of transition, as late modernity. Many scholarly debates in the social and cultural sciences are concerned with a description and interpretation of the current transition and have identified a variety of possible indicators.

A focal point in the debate on late modernity is the change in the role of the nation-state and attention is drawn to the multiple embeddings of its key institutions and their organizations such as education. In fact, much in the work of comparative education, especially of comparative policy analysis, investigates the ensuing new forms, actors and instruments with regards to the three dimensions of policy, politics and polities. In the context of describing and analyzing this era of transition or transformation, the discussion by Robert Cowen stands out because he has placed the term “transitology” at the center of his reflections (Cowen, 1996, 2000), for which he suggests the following definition: “[...] the more or less simultaneous collapse and reconstruction of (a) state apparatuses; (b) social and economic stratification systems; and (c) political visions of the future; in which (d) education is given a major symbolic and reconstructionist role in these social processes of destroying the past and redefining the future.” (Cowen, 2000, p. 338). Arguably, we do not

S. K. Amos (✉)

Institute of Education, Eberhard Karls University of Tübingen, Tübingen, Germany

e-mail: karin.amos@uni-tuebingen.de

© The Author(s), under exclusive license to Springer Nature

Switzerland AG 2022

M. Parreira do Amaral, C. Thompson (eds.), *Geopolitical Transformations in Higher Education*, Educational Governance Research 17,

https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-94415-5_4

often see state apparatuses collapse in the dramatic sense of the fall of the Berlin wall and the following recalibration of the geo-political system on a global scale. Generally speaking, not only the political systems but the established social and economic stratification systems as well seem to be quite stable. However, we do see more fundamental battles over the symbolic meaning of education, indicating that the perceived stability and coherence may be treacherous. For one, as is broadly discussed for two decades by now, the relation between state and education systems changes and if we employ Cowen's term more loosely, we may designate the shift from state-centered to market-centered as an indication of the current "transitology". One vision of education for late modernity can, roughly speaking, be described as a technological one operating with the mindset of efficiency, maximization and optimization. Another vision of education, one that is more inspired by a relational mindset and a system's view of life, is not yet part of the mainstream. These largely opposing views or visions of the future of education are at the core of the following essay, which is a strong invitation to engage in further discussion, especially with regards to the overall focus of the book, i.e. higher education. The argument builds upon a brief reflection on the role of education in modernity (here defined as the period between the last third of the eighteenth century to the last third of the twentieth century) and its state-centered organization, and the late modern shift to a market-centered organization in the first section. The second section then deals with a phenomenon that is increasingly discussed in education as well, i.e., digitalization and algorithmization and the related debate on transhumanism. With regard to the latter, it is enhancement, augmentation and optimization, that are of particular interest and relevance in the context of education. These developments in turn illustrate the link to education being increasingly market-centered. In the third section, I will confront this perspective with a different notion of the relation between humans and their technology; a perspective known as posthumanism. Here, Donna Haraway's position seems to be particularly thought-provoking for a vision of education in late modernity. This section also marks a shift: from a descriptive to a normative one as I here take a pedagogical stand and argue for a direction that we might wish for education to take.

4.2 From Modern State-Centered to Late Modern Market-Centered Education

It is without question that modern education and its academic reflection are deeply implicated in the organization of societies as nation-states. Despite many criticisms of macro-sociological phenomenological neo-institutionalism associated with the so-called Stanford School founded by John W. Meyer and colleagues, I still find their work on "The political construction of mass education" (Ramirez & Boli, 1987) very convincing. In this and similar articles, they reconstruct the interest of emerging nation-states in the eighteenth Century as the founding context of modern

mass education. In their view, the nation-state is the result of a specific geo-political dynamics in Europe together with changes in the economic and religious systems. Part of the make-up of nation-states is a specific view of belonging and membership', which eventually came to be expressed in citizenship. State and citizens are tied to each other by a specific bond of rights and duties but also by an imaginative or symbolic realm that defines the highly institutionalized values, norms and belief systems. This very special relation is prominently expressed in education, which becomes the key institution of the nation-state as it is here that membership is created, bonds of loyalty and belonging established, but also boundaries drawn. The nation-state is only inclusive with regards to its (future) citizens, not to outsiders. The status of foreigner, which is defined by a foreign passport, provides only restricted access to resources, both real and symbolic. While public education was envisioned as being universal, in the sense of including both sexes, disregarding religious and social class affiliations, these "universalities" did not extent past the borders of the nation, and even within national contexts, may only be "ceremonially" be realized.

To illustrate this point, we may refer to historical and current controversies around the question of who has access to education. Until today, this question is relevant as the controversies around schooling for children of refugees, (im)migrants, or so-called illegal aliens illustrate. As any model, it is a simplified version of a very complex reality, but it draws the attention of the membership-creating function of mass schooling.

When scholars today claim a shift from state- to market-centered relations of education, they do not deny that usefulness and productivity did play a role in previous centuries. Of course, membership in the national community was connected to expectations of becoming an economically independent individual contributing to the well-being of the collective. The more so, as economic growth is a central tenet of modernity, related to progress and perfectibility. Nevertheless, the relations have changed quite dramatically: what used to be described as state-driven is now market-driven. In order to understand this more fully, I refer again to Robert Cowen, who has visualized the difference between modern and late modern education in a two-axis model intersecting in the middle. The vertical axis of the "modern model" is "polis driven: Equality of educational opportunity" as its upper designation and "national cultural identity" on the lower end, with "international education relations" on the left and "economic growth" on the right of the horizontal axis (Cowen, 1996, p. 160). The second, "late modern" model follows the same scheme, again we have two axes intersecting in the middle, the upper end of the vertical axis has "polis driven" replaced by "market driven", and "equality of educational opportunity" replaced by "internal efficiency and external effectiveness". On the lower end, "national cultural identity" is replaced by "differentiation of labour force". On the left and right side of the horizontal axis we find the "international economy" and "international knowledge" competition (ibid., p. 162).

Without question, these models are highly simplistic. They leave out all kinds of power relations expressed in a welter of relations of "difference" of access and only hint at cultural or symbolic violence expressed in the "national cultural" identity.

We need to keep in mind that these models, Cowen's or Meyer's like all models are condensations, abstractions and simplifications of an incredibly complex and rich reality.

In the years that have elapsed since Cowen's publications, there has been an incredibly rich and fruitful academic output on these new educational relations where the market replaces the state. The very fact that the terminology of new public management is already so deeply ingrained in our current educational structures is a striking illustration. We are all familiar with the discourses and practices of efficiency, effectivity, performance, quality assurance, public-private-partnerships, entrepreneurship education etc. for all tiers of the education system. The main referent being human capital development and the knowledge-based economy. Again, this by itself is not new and I would like to bring to mind Cowen's observation that past, present and future are more intertwined than strictly linear. The German novelist Günther Grass has established *VerGegenKunft* (a combination of *Vergangenheit*, *Gegenwart*, *Zukunft* for past, present and future) as a literary principle to illustrate this entanglement. To elucidate how the present was foreshadowed in the past, let us take the example of "knowledge" as a pivotal element in the shift from state to market-driven. Since the late nineteen fifties "knowledge" is discussed as a productive factor in economic theories and since the famous Sputnik Shock does the OECD take an interest in education, especially in the STEM-subjects. Long before the discussion on the pivotal role of the market became prevalent, in fact at a time when the welfare state was about to expand significantly in the post- World War II years, the relation between economy and knowledge was forged.

4.3 Digitalization and Market-Centered Education

Market-driven or market-centered education has another aspect on which I would like to focus on next, i.e., the provision of education. Education itself becomes a tradable good. A highly conducive factor pushing the provision of education and its commercial aspects is digitalization. There is no question about this. It will be very interesting to see after the current pandemic is over, how education has changed system-wide. But even without COVID-19, digitalization was well under way to deeply transform education. Digitalization redraws boundaries in profound ways. It is strongly promoted by all education stakeholders: International Intergovernmental Organizations (such as The World Bank, UNESCO; the OECD; the EU) but also by NGO's, by national governments, foundations, industry, especially the Educational Technology business. The motives are manifold. And here just the most salient will be considered. Since we are dealing with digitalization in the logics of the economic and commercial aspects: (1) Profit – the EdTech Industry is big business with growing shares in the stock market. It is not surprising that all of the familiar names in ICT corporations, Google, Apple, Microsoft, are all running big departments on education. It is also a prime area for start-ups and for companies such as Sylvan Learning Systems and many other providers in K-12 education. In higher education,

we find virtual universities such as Udacity or Coursera, to mention only two of the most familiar names in the business, often related to lifelong learning. (2) Justice and equality – this might be a surprise, but it is a logical consequence of the very characteristics of virtual provision of education. UNESCO promotes digitalization because although the development of digital material and formats is quite cost-intensive, it can be replicated and adapted almost infinitely and is hence easy to diffuse. The anytime, anywhere principle responds to differences in life world and individual circumstances. In some cases, there are not enough brick and mortar structures, i.e., physical buildings to ensure that those that have to be reached can be reached. This is a problem of the entire life span, from schooling, via tertiary education to adult and further education. For all ages access to the desired/needed educational and professional qualification is a problem that ICT offers promise to solve. This relates (3) also to professional development of teachers but also the creation of new jobs. An education evangelist such as Google's Jaime Casap promotes the educational use of technology on global platforms. This is one more facet showing how the geo-politics of education is changing. The keyword professional development relates more immediately to improving the quality of learning, such as learning analytics and personalized learning.

Increasingly, digitalization is the main structure for the entire operations of universities (and schools as well, of course): from student administration, via course provision to the issuing of diplomas and certificates, everything is running on ICT. The trend for digitalization and algorithmization also pushes regional university alliances. As universities are increasingly operating under a globally competitive framework, driven by rankings, but also by national and transnational political interest, they resort to creating synergies by seeking out partners according to their needs. In some cases, these may be political such as The League of European Research Universities (LERU) or The GUILD; they also may be the result of international initiatives such as the European University Alliances under the framework established by the European Commission. We find these alliances in all world regions with many of them even crossing continental boundaries. They collaborate in research, they promote mobility of students and staff, they develop joint or double degree study programs and they also respond to or pursue political agendas. Of course, universities have always interacted and collaborated internationally. But the ambition of universities in high modernity, i.e., in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries was to become the keystones of national education systems. The drive for a stronger regional integration sometimes clashes with the insistence on autonomy; an argument that is also often brought forth vis á vis national ministries responsible for establishing the regulative framework and overseeing the operations of universities. In a similar manner, regional integration promotes the trend towards standardization, while universities also have great persisting forces to retain their own *modi operandi*. The fact that the Bologna Process is implemented and realized in great variation across the European Higher Education Era testifies to this. To sum up: Digitalization leaves hardly anything untouched, from how education is delivered, its new forms of teaching and learning, its role in educational administration, teacher training, to name but the most obvious aspects. And all of these can be

commercialized. It is also a prime example for geopolitical transformation of education in all realms of education and especially of higher education. At the same time, it is also confronted with counter-forces, so that the geo-political education space may be described as multi-layered.

4.4 Perfectibility Revisited: The Transhumanist Dream of Infinite Optimization

Thus far, I may have conveyed the impression that digitalization and marketization is very compatible with justice and equality. Because of their inherent options for flexibility, digitalization is responsive to diversity and answers more appropriately to specific needs of students than the traditional one-size-fits-all model. In higher education, because of the many responsibilities students have to shoulder, a more flexible provision which does not require their full-time physical presence on campus, having more organizational freedom instead of rigid time schedules seems to be the road to travel. Also, with regards to international student exchange, virtual participation opens up new possibilities for students who do not have the means to go abroad. Hence, more students can experience an international exposure than ever before, which, by the way, is also positive in terms of the ecological footprint. This being said, there are also indications of digitalization causing or at least increasing inequality. Not all students own adequate hardware or are in places with good connections to the world-wide web. Better funded universities are likely to invest more in the pedagogy of digitalization to ensure successful teaching and learning. The fact alone that course offerings are more flexible is not in and by itself a guarantee for more social justice and equality. This becomes even more obvious, when looking at another trend closely related with digitalization and algorithmization. It is a trend the implications of which for social justice and equality are not yet fully explored. I refer to a movement that is known as transhumanism. There is a vision of education for late modernity, which one may designate as trans-humanist in the sense of transcending the limits of being human and “by design”. The core idea may be said to envision the frail human being of being catapulted to the next levels of performance and longevity. I am thinking here in particular of examples such as Natasha Vita More’s body by design project. This vision is very compatible with Cowen’s market driven model. It is hyper-individualist, it is cost-intensive. From physical interventions to optimize the human body to technologically enhanced cognitive augmentation, it is clear that these offerings are only for selected few and not for humanity as such. Although many transhumanists also speak of connectivity, they not associate with it a radical relatedness of all biological and artificial organisms, or if so, then only ritualistically. As a form of cult or a techno-religion, trans-humanism is selective and exclusive, is far from being for everyone. It also resonates with the aim of education as the differentiation of the work force (to remind us of Cowen’s model of education and late modernity); even in the high-tech world of

transhumanists not all human beings are free to pursue to their self-optimizing dreams and freely choose their occupations. If this vision of education for late modernity became the dominant one, we would see the dominance of a high-end global education technology industry setting the standards and the pace. Transhumanism may be said to be the radicalization of high modernity, with the dream of immortality, rationality, autonomy, masters of our destinies, designers of ourselves. The consequence of realizing the transhumanist vision would be clear distinctions in provision and of access. I think that this issue has to be addressed more fundamentally than the aspects mentioned thus far i.e., the differences in hard- and software or inequality of availability of high quality and reliable technological infrastructure. At the heart of the transhumanist project is the question of who is considered to be fully human and thus can be addressed for optimization and perfection. Again, to use the *Vergegenkunft*-concept of Günter Grass, it makes sense to look to the past to see the present and the future. One of the keys to understanding the current transhumanist movement is Julian Huxley, first director general of UNESCO, proponent of scientific or evolutionary humanism and eugenics and promoter of human rights. In a collection of essays entitled *New Bottles for New Wine* (1957) he suggested the following definition for transhumanism:

The human species can, if it wishes, transcend itself – not just sporadically, an individual here in one way, an individual there in another way, but in its entirety, as humanity. We need a name for his new belief. Perhaps *transhumanism* will serve: man remains man but transcends himself, by realizing new possibilities of and for human nature. (ibid., p. 17)

As a utopian vision, belief or ideology, transhumanism is universal and includes mankind as such; but when turned into technological practice, its limitations become obvious – not to mention its speciesist bias.

4.4.1 Visions of Education for Late Modernity, Part I

Again, we may refer to the current crisis to see a bit more clearly where we might be heading. It may be premature, but for the sake of provocation, I predict that the model of universal mass schooling will increasingly be under pressure in the decades to come. I do not mean to state that it will suddenly disappear, but its authoritative and legitimitative powers will become weaker, exacerbated by the present situation, where home schooling becomes a global reality. So in the future we might see a greater variety of simultaneous forms. This is also true for higher education, where the default mode of on-campus provision for mostly young people entering the institutions after graduating from secondary schooling will also be increasingly confronted by a variety of other forms. In both cases K-12 as well as higher education, digitalization is a key in explaining the proliferation of forms and modes of institutionalization. As stated previously, even under market conditions, digitalization has potential to advance social justice and equality, but not automatically so. Uneven access, uneven provision of infrastructure, hard- and software; uneven

professional skills, uneven readiness and familiarity of students with independent and largely self-directed use of technology, will increase the trend of social polarization. In addition, there is much criticism of schools more so than of universities, not to be digitally up to speed. At the same time, the membership creating function becomes weaker. As hinted at earlier, membership in this sense is closely linked to the nation-state as the standard geo-political unit of organizing societies. Large public education institutions carry the biggest burden in socializing young people to assume their future roles as citizens and contributors to the collective good. But the scenario of a future proliferation of all kinds of forms of education including highly personalized ones with individualized credentials, counters the common experience and is a problem for democracies. Parents investing much in the material and non-material support of their children are becoming impatient with seeing them learning in the same settings as less fortunate children from less willing and able parents to provide the necessary support. How this plays out in the end, is open. But the auguries are not very favorable. As our present involuntary laboratory situation, where due to the pandemic, education globally was catapulted in the digital orbit, shows: Digitalization is not a homogenous movement with the same global implications for education. It causes new inequalities between and within countries and regions. Although the setting is different from a dependence on physical buildings with classrooms and lecture halls, it still requires a sound and reliable infrastructure that is far from being sufficiently established. Digitalization also implies difference in the offerings, from very sophisticated software including virtual or augmented reality settings to rather primitive platforms; from pedagogically elaborate and artistically demanding video productions to audio-visual material in poor quality. It is obvious that technology by itself is not the answer, it takes pedagogically knowledgeable and versatile teaching personnel on all educational levels. The bottom line of these very sweeping generalizations is: Education in late modernity will be more fragmented, more heterogenous, more uneven. Perhaps we will even see the end of universalized schooling which was the trademark of high modernity. *Prima vista*, this version of the vision of education for late modernity too, is reactive rather than proactive. It reacts to new formations, symbolically and physically, formations which we discuss under the simplified umbrella term of globalization, with its driving force of economic competition and therefore the educational stimulation of competitiveness. This may also be said to be at the bottom of our current educational geo-political reformation. What is lacking in many debates is a pedagogical vision, not in the sense of *how* to teach, which in German is known as *Didaktik* but in the fundamental sense as a vision of education, an answer to the question: How do we want to live together? Let me be clear here: I not rooting for a homogenous vision, there is no single answer and there should not be one. The following sections discuss positions that might be helpful for further discussions.

4.5 Education, Relationality and “World Making”

This part of my musings is admittedly highly speculative. It takes its cues from contributions outside of the proper sphere of education and pedagogy. It looks for diagnoses of our current state of society on a global scale without following the logics of what we simplistically mean by globalization. One is Donna Haraway’s *Staying with the Trouble*, the other is Arturo Escobar’s *Designs for the Pluriverse*, published in 2016 and 2018 respectively. Both publications focus strongly on the idea of “world making”, or in Escobar’s terms “worlds making”, or the “making of pluriverses” (Escobar, 2018), in Donna Haraway’s terms: “worlding” (Haraway, 2016). A third version would be a theological-philosophical one following Simone Weil, known as “mondialisation” (Supiot, 2019). Mondialisation recurs to the original meaning of globalization as coined by the Belgian biologist Ovide Decroly in 1929. In this view, globalization is a cognitive function to comprehend reality in its entirety without a previous knowledge of its composing elements (Supiot, 2019, loc. 94). In this sense, mondialisation or American English “mundialization” has the planetary ecumene in view, the regard for life and the respect for its pluri- or multi-forms and is used as a counter-concept to our present of common understanding of globalization as closely related to the market, to flexibilization of labor and cultural homogeneity.

These approaches share the same basic concern. Escobar’s central instrument of description and analysis is “design” in the late modern sense of an encompassing engagement with wicked problems transcending the realm of single disciplines or single realms of action (Escobar, 2018; Manzini, 2015). The understanding of design in this sense, as a way of dealing with the challenges of our time, from decolonialism via postextractivism, alternative models to economic growth as we know it, issues of sustainment etc. is closely related to dealing with transitions.

The literature on transitions makes it clear that transitions are not designed but emergent. They depend on a mix of interacting processes, both self-organizing and other-organized (by humans). Emergence, [...] takes place on the basis of a multiplicity of local actions that, through their (largely unplanned) interaction, give rise to what appears to an observer to be a new structure of integrated whole [...] without the need for any central planning or intelligence guiding the process. [...] Ideas about emergence, self-organization, and autopoiesis can be important elements in rethinking theories of social change. (Escobar, 2018, p. 152)

The central task then is to bring together the debates on transitions with more recent developments on thinking about design. For Escobar, the main point is in grounding transition design (1) in “living systems’ theory as an approach to understanding/addressing wicked problems.” By this he is mainly referring to the groundbreaking work of Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela, two biologists who have revolutionized our thinking about life as a great system which by extension also refers to the social realm. The work cited here was written by both and published in 1987: *The Tree of Knowledge*;

(2) Design solutions that protect and restore *both* social and natural ecosystems; (3) Sees everyday life/styles as the most fundamental context of design; (4) Advocates place-based,

globally networked solutions; (5) Designs solutions for varying horizons of time and multiple levels of scale; (6) Links existing solutions so that they become steps in a larger transition vision; (7) amplifies emergent, grassroots solutions; (8) Bases solutions on maximizing satisfiers for the widest range of needs; (9) Sees the designer's own mindset/posture as an essential component of the design process; (10) Calls for the reintegration and recontextualization of diverse transdisciplinary knowledge. (Irwin, 2015, p. 3, quoted in Escobar, 2018, p. 158)

Against the background of what has been said earlier, it is obvious that Escobar does not mention any large collectives such as the nation-state. His vision for solving mankind's problems is by delegation to smaller units, solutions "on the ground", so to speak, who by networking and connecting will contribute to finding solutions on a global scale. But, here the crucial difference comes in: while globalization is identified as a hegemonic project, mundialization or world making takes the specific life worlds as its main referent. This is also the impression one gets from reading Donna Haraway. Her main focus is not on design, but on narratives. She relies on SF as the creative force. SF has many meanings, among others, string figures, speculative fabulation, science fiction, string, figures, but also simply so far. The telling of stories is a central idea, the creation of patterns involving many actors, human and non-human with different capacities. Both authors despite their differences have a similar mind frame and intersecting intellectual preferences. Interconnectedness figures prominently in both oeuvres, but in Haraway's world, there is not only primarily human connectedness, but a connectedness of "critters", for which Haraway's life partner, Rusten Hogness, coined the term humosity to indicate a world where the human is radically decentered and one part in a huge recycling process of dying and becoming. Haraway is certainly post-redemption, also post-optimism, with a radical focus on the present. The main idea of her book is to live and die well together in a thick present. There may not be a future, who knows? But there definitely is a present, a rich here and now, which is passed by all too easily, although it is all we have and the only time-space (at least for biological organisms to live in). Escobar's tone is overall more hopeful in the sense of finding solutions that may work on a larger scale through association and connection. Both thinkers offer visions not only of but also for late modernity as communal, inter- and intra-active, radically interconnected. Whereas Escobar places autopoiesis, the self-referentiality of organisms which he takes from Varela at the center, Haraway speaks of sympoiesis, being together with, humble, response-able to answer to each other's needs. Haraway stresses the difference between sympoiesis and autopiesis and dismisses the latter's emphasis on self-referentiality, but in the end, both positions have more things uniting than separating them. Both positions are post-growth in the classical sense, skeptical of globalization, they look for different models than capitalism and, as already mentioned, they radically de-center the human especially in the sense of its most prominent modern presentation, the white European or Western male.

What exactly are the implications of these radical re-positionings of being in the world, of reading and making worlds, of nurturing response-ability? It is quite obvious that none of the forms and provisions of education as we know it, addresses the concerns of these visions. In the final part, I will discuss the implications more fully.

4.5.1 *Visions of Education, Part II*

The diagnosis of scholars like Escobar and Haraway is clear enough: Without a significant change, not to say transformation of our mind-set, late modernity may as well be the last stage not only for humanity, but for the planet. Interestingly enough, education is not a major point in their diagnosis and suggestions for remedies. The explanation for this could be twofold. On the one hand, both do not invoke mass education as we know it, because – in line with their argument – it is part of the problem and not of the solution, be it state-centered or market-centered. The DNA of education including its current transformations promising a more personalized provision through algorithmization and digitalization, is the basis of the mindset that created the global problems which they address in the first place: competition, growth, “rugged individualism”, etc., i. e., reliance on Western rationality as the only access to valid knowledge. Therefore, mass education with its close link to the geo-political space of the nation-state cannot show a way out of the present predicament. The other explanation for not dealing with education is that they both seem to take socialization and education for granted. Education will thus automatically be a result of the communal transformation. For Haraway, the basis of the communities she envisions in the last part of “Staying with the Trouble” is SF. It is the pleasure in creating worlds through speculative fabulations and string figures, that is the mixing and blending across species driven by the ability to respond, to be sensitive to each other’s needs and to care for life in all its forms. Despite the stress on storytelling and narratives, Haraway is also a representative of the new materialism. Education for her would entail being materially and physically connected. If one would have to name an educational theory that is compatible with her visions, it would be John Dewey rather than Wilhelm von Humboldt or Maria Montessori. One of the main sources in Escobar’s work is Varela’s *Ethical Know-How* (1999), where he proposes the non-solidity of the self, or the subject, proposing the notion of a selfless or virtual self as an emergent property of a distributed system mediated by social inter-actions (Varela, 1999, pp. 52–63, quoted in Escobar, p. 126). For Escobar as well as for Haraway the acceptance of the non-solidity of the self gives rise to a fundamental disposition of caring. From this arises the question of how to foster and nourish this attitude or disposition in our collective form of living. The answer is a rejection of the established responses of education as we know it: through rationalistic interventions, through self-optimization, through norms. Rather, the ethics of caring must be nurtured through a suspension of the ego, via disciplines that are conducive to develop habits that are not self-centered, that validate spontaneous compassion and non-duality (Escobar, 2018, p. 127).

Whereas transhumanists flourish in a world of inequality of means, resources, goods etc., posthumanists of the ink of Escobar or Haraway have no use for stratification unless it is functional. The cult about social distinctions is alien to them. The envision communal lives of caring and response-ability, where the individual participates in the well-being of all, but is not the group and not of the individual is at the center. Although in no way identical, there are certain family resemblances with

the African notion of *Ubuntu* and the Latin American concept of *Buen Vivir*, perhaps in both cases a little more with regards to the latter. Myths, cosmologies, alternative narratives to the master narrative of progress and perfectibility figure prominently in the works of both thinkers, they freely integrate science with other epistemologies, both of their pluriverses are small entities, they envision life in groups which means small communities with much direct contact.

It is hard to see education with rigid structures of knowledge compartmentalization, curricula, class promotion, grading systems compatible with this vision of education for late modernity. One thinks rather of small units, almost in a pre-modern sense as learning by imitation or in the mode of the ancient academy.

As stated earlier, mass education as we know it, is hard to reconcile with these versions of post-humanism. However, as attractive as these visions are, they also create problems. Public education, K-12 as well as higher education, are multi-layered systems embedded and configured in a variety of environments, or in current parlance, part of complex ecosystems. It is one of the great achievements of modernity of having created a public sphere of which education is a major component, where what is taught and how it is taught is observed, critiqued, revised. The very criticism of mass education, from Illich (1971), via Bowles and Gintis (1976) to Bourdieu and Passeron (1977), to mention only the most prominent positions, is also an indication of its strength. Although mass education does not always fulfill its mission of drawing out the potential of every member of the young generation, it is still accountable and not “let off the hook”. Discourses on educational justice and equality would look very differently if education were to become solely a communal affair. What is needed then, is an educational theory that draws it all together. One that re-envision public education with a non-compartmentalized organization of knowledge, that takes connectivity and response-ability, another term for caring as its organizing principle, one that encourages collaboration, is critical of ideologies that place the human being at the center of the universe, one that encourages non-dualistic thinking and the non-fixity of the self, pays attention to the multiple entanglements both material and non-material.

References

- Bourdieu, P., & Passeron, J.-C. (1977). *Reproduction in education, society and culture*. Sage.
- Bowles, S., & Gintis, H. (1976). *Schooling in capitalist America. Educational reform and the contradictions of economic life*. Basic Books.
- Cowen, R. (1996). Last past the post: Comparative education, modernity and perhaps post-modernity. *Comparative Education*, 32(1), 151–170.
- Cowen, R. (2000). Comparing futures or comparing pasts. *Comparative Education*, 36(3), 333–342.
- Decroly, O. (1929). *La Fonction de globalization et l'Enseignement*. Lamartine.
- Escobar, A. (2018). *Designs for the pluriverse. Radical interdependence, autonomy, and the making of worlds*. Duke University Press.
- Haraway, D. (2016). *Staying with the trouble. Making Kin in the Chuthulence*. Duke University Press.
- Huxley, J. (1957). *New bottles for new wine*. Chatto & Windus.

- Ilich, I. (1971). *Deschooling society*. Harper & Row.
- Irwin, T. (2015). Transition Design: A Proposal for a New Area of Design Practice, Study, and Research. *Design and Culture*, 7(2), 229–246. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17547075.2015.1051829>.
- Manzini, E. (2015). *Design. When everybody designs. An introduction to design as social innovation*. MIT Press.
- Maturana, H. R., & Varela, F. J. (1998 [1987]). *The tree of knowledge. The biological roots of human understanding*. Shambhala.
- Parreira do Amaral, M. (2011). *Emergenz eines internationalen bildungsregimes? International educational governance und regimetheorie*. Münster: Waxmann.
- Ramirez, F. O., & Boli, J. (1987). The political construction of mass schooling: European origins and worldwide institutionalization. *Sociology of Education*, 60(1), 2–17.
- Supiot, A. (2019). *Mondialisation ou globalization. Les leçons de Simone Weil. Collège de France*. Édition imprimée.
- Varela, F. J. (1999). *Ethical know-how: Action, wisdom and cognition*. Stanford University Press.